



A knee at the table: Jay-Z, Colin Kaepernick, and the endurance of competing strategies in Black social justice

Lily Kunda*¹

¹Africana Studies, William & Mary, Williamsburg, VA, USA and American Studies, William & Mary, Williamsburg, VA, USA

*Corresponding author: Lily Kunda. Email: lkunda@wm.edu

Abstract

In August 2019, the U.S. National Football League (NFL) and entertainment company Roc-Nation entered into a partnership to amplify the league's "social justice efforts." This partnership received mixed reactions from news media and fans with significant negative criticism. Many accused the NFL of using the celebrity reputation of Roc-Nation founder, Jay-Z, for cultural capital to recoup from the negative press received following the 2016 protest of Colin Kaepernick. This article examines the media discourse following the announcement of the partnership and how it perpetuates a long-existing ideological feud within Black social justice that questions if the path to racial progress must be achieved with the help of white institutions. I argue that the adoption of neoliberal ideologies into contemporary activism has shifted focus from the needs of the communities being served to the brand image and market profits of celebrity activists and corporations.

Keywords: social justice, celebrity activism, sports media, race.

A match made in heaven? From protest to progress

On August 13, 2019, the U.S. National Football League (NFL) announced they were entering into a partnership with Roc Nation, an entertainment company founded by music mogul Shawn "Jay-Z" Carter. According to the press release, the purpose of the partnership would be to "enhance the NFL's live game experiences and to amplify the league's social justice efforts" (Around the NFL, 2019). Jay-Z would take on the role of "Live Music Entertainment Strategists." NFL commissioner, Roger Goodell stated:

(...) we listened to our players. We understood what our players were saying, and we created a platform which can help drive change that Colin had raised, and the players had raised. This partnership, in addition to bringing the entertainment aspect to it with bringing football and music together, is going to help us make even greater change. We call it protest to progress. (Reyes, 2019)

The need to improve the league's social justice efforts came as a result of copious media attention and perceived racial discrimination following the public protest by former 49ers player Colin Kaepernick in the 2016–17 NFL season in which he attempted to draw attention to the issue of police brutality. The situation ended in a lawsuit between Kaepernick and the NFL and a boycott of the NFL by some viewers. Despite being two years removed from Kaepernick's protest, the NFL was still recouping its reputation and needed the added cultural capital of a celebrity like Jay-Z. In a \$25 million U.S. deal, in his new role, Jay-Z would be in charge of revamping the Super Bowl halftime show as well as collaborating with the league's existing Inspire Change social justice campaign that focuses on education and economic advancement, police and community relations, and criminal justice reform (Lockhart, 2019; Thompson, 2023).

Initial reactions to the partnership were mixed. Some expressed that the partnership was a positive step in the right direction for social justice coming off the heels of the Kaepernick controversy. For example, one Twitter user tweeted, "Boss move! Presents a unique platform for good biz, while simultaneously impacting unity & social change globally. Amazing what can happen when opposing sides listen."¹ Journalist Nana Efu Mumford (2019) wrote, "Now that he's at the table, Jay-Z can represent a new voice and perhaps influence the NFL's decisions and conversations. He might even pull up a seat for others who might not have had the opportunity to be seen or heard." Those in support of the partnership touched on how monumental the partnership could be for the Black community and that Jay-Z was the perfect candidate for the role due to his business savvy and passion for racial equity. While many were supportive of the positive possibilities of this partnership, an overwhelming number of responses were negative. The Internet was riddled with articles like: "Half Sellout, Half Savior: What Jay-Z's NFL Deal and Possible Team Ownership Really Mean" (Aswad, 2019b), "Jay-Z Helped the NFL Banish Colin Kaepernick" (Hill, 2019), and "Not Like This: An Open Letter to Jay-Z" (Harriot, 2019). It appeared that a large consensus believed Jay-Z was betraying Kaepernick by working with the NFL and that the NFL was using Jay-Z—arguably the most famous Black rapper—to gain credibility with the Black community. According to Duvall and Heckemeyer (2018, p. 392), it is not uncommon for contemporary celebrity activism to occur through partnerships with organizations.

Sarah Banet-Weiser (2012, p. 127) implores us to pay close attention to "historical and current struggles over what political activism means; who takes shape as activists in contemporary society; and whom such activism is imagined to serve." With this in mind, I view the mixed reactions received in response to the NFL/Roc-Nation partnership as an example of a current struggle over the meaning of activism.

Received: 26 July 2023. Revised: 3 September 2024. Accepted: 22 September 2024

© The Author(s) 2024. Published by Oxford University Press on behalf of International Communication Association. All rights reserved. For commercial re-use, please contact reprints@oup.com for reprints and translation rights for reprints. All other permissions can be obtained through our RightsLink service via the Permissions link on the article page on our site—for further information please contact journals.permissions@oup.com.

By viewing the discourse that erupted in response to the partnership from a historical lens, I discover that the tensions that framed Jay-Z as a capitalist “sellout” and Kaepernick as a martyr are an extension of existing debates within Black American social justice movements wherein integrationist and separatist approaches are positioned against one another in the news media and the Black community with disagreement on which approach is most effective (Carson, 2005). In other words, these debates center on whether Black people should work with white institutions towards racial progress or against them.

Historically, the white institutions in question were U.S. state and government organizations. However, in this contemporary moment, the white institutions take the form of corporations enacting corporate social responsibility (CSR) efforts. This is due to what Henry Giroux (2002) describes as the growth of corporate culture under neoliberal dystopia. To Giroux, “civic discourse has given way to the language of commercialism, privatization, and deregulation. In addition, individual and social agency are defined largely through market-driven notions of individualism, competition, and consumption” (p. 425). He argues that democratic values have been “reduced to an instrument of the entrepreneurial self” (2001, p. 1). Activism and corporate culture have become intertwined under the push for all aspects of life—even politics—to be marketized and commodified. This added layer to an existing debate is indicative of shifting ideas on what “political activism means” and the central focus on celebrities Jay-Z and Kaepernick highlights “who takes shape as activists in contemporary society.” I argue the U.S. news media propels the ideological feud by focusing media attention on celebrity and corporate images. I tie these shifts to what can be understood as the new social justice paradigm that utilizes representative activism and communicative capitalism in the place of addressing governmental and structural systems. It is vital to interrogate the contemporary iterations of this long existing debate because as Banet-Weiser (2012) contends, we must tend to whom political activism is imagined to serve. In this new paradigm of social justice, the beneficiaries of the activism are the celebrities and corporations who receive positive media attention for their brand as opposed to the communities who need redress. As education attainment, imprisonment, unemployment, and household income disparities for Black Americans continue to persist (Economic Policy Institute, 2022), news media should provide deeper critical engagement on the multifaceted needs of the Black community as opposed to added public relations and branded media marketing for celebrities and corporations. To contextualize my argument, I begin by laying the foundation on how competing approaches towards racial equity in the US have manifested historically in the Black American community and the role celebrities play in activism efforts.

Competing approaches to racial progress

In studies of social movements across disciplines, the effectiveness of tactics and strategy has consistently remained an area of focus. According to Maney et al. (2012), even when there is agreement within a movement on what goals need be pursued and why they matter, scholars have varied in their assumptions regarding how those goals should best be pursued through strategy (p. xvii). Specifically, within Black

social justice efforts, the debate focuses on whether an integrationist or separatist (sometimes called nationalist) approach (Hutchinson, 1993; Villemez & Beggs, 1984) is most effective. According to Villemez and Beggs (1984), “we may divide prescriptions for black progress (...) according to whether they see the route to progress as necessitating assimilation of blacks into white society or the complete separation of blacks from white society (into separatist and integrationists’ categories)” (p. 118). Within these two camps separatists have historically been viewed as militant or radical as their tactics are framed as less cooperative, whereas integrationists are viewed as moderate as their tactics emphasize compromise with white America. Throughout history Black activists and political leaders have been placed in the frame of these two opposing approaches in the news media and public discourse of those concerned with Black American activism.

An early example of this debate was seen amongst W.E.B. Du Bois and Booker T. Washington. Washington promoted the philosophy of accommodating white oppression whereas DuBois believed in more militant persistent agitation and political action (Gibson et al., 2019). According to Hutchinson (1993), Du Bois believed Washington’s integrationist attitude, “practically accepts the alleged inferiority of the Negro races” (p. 16). To Du Bois, separate but equal was a more acceptable option for Black Americans and as a result, “the Washington/Du Bois dispute polarized African American leaders into two wings—the ‘conservative’ supporters of Washington and his ‘radical’ critics” (Frontline, 2023). As Earl Ofari Hutchinson (1993) claims, “During the 1960s, Washington’s name became an epithet young black militants flung at anyone they considered an ‘Uncle Tom’” (p. 16). This iteration reveals anyone who aligns themselves with the white community is pejoratively viewed as an Uncle Tom and on the opposing named as being “militant.” These two paradigms of thinking—integrationist/moderate versus separatist/radical—have persisted and manifested in numerous iterations of Black social justice through time. At times, the activists may have participated in the dichotomy by calling out their ideological adversary’s views, but often, the news media did much of the work to construct the leaders into opponents.

A prominent example of this ideological debate in American history occurred between activists Dr Martin Luther King and Malcolm X during the Civil Rights Era. Dr King’s legacy is historicized in the American imagination as having an approach that stressed non-violence, working alongside various organizations towards racial resolution, and pushing for integration—working *with* white people for liberation. Malcolm X, in contrast, is most remembered for advocating for independence from white America and supporting the use of violence if necessary. According to Clayborne Carson (2005, p. 22):

Their sometimes rancorous debate, carried on through public statements rather than direct dialogue, set the tone for the disruptive, even deadly ideological and tactical conflicts within black communities in the years since their deaths. Contemporary black young people seeking social justice are still torn between racial integration and racial separation, between Martin’s call for nonviolent resistance and Malcolm’s insistence on ‘any means necessary.’

Though Dr King's and X's approaches ebbed and flowed, with both figures evolving from their primary standpoints to more all-encompassing approaches, discourse in popular culture, media, and even some academic texts, nevertheless, emphasizes a perceived feud between them. Both men utilized protest, mobilizing communities through speech, media, community development, and culling of resources and many of the actual methods they used in their activism were, in fact, similar. Just like Dr King and X's renowned legacies for activism in the Black community have remained, unfortunately, so has the reductive discourse around them that positions them in opposition. Furthermore, this discourse continues to be recycled on new American Black figures who have opposing views.

Another notable example of this recycled dichotomy occurred in the 1990s and 2000s with Reverends Jesse Jackson and Al Sharpton who held differing approaches to social justice, with Sharpton being positioned as more radical than Jackson (Hosenball, 2001; Newfield, 2002). Speaking of Sharpton's campaign, a 1994 *New York Magazine* article reads, "Like the battles taking place nationally—over integration, separatism, Afrocentrism, Farrakhan—is also about philosophy and outlook. It is a fight over who will set the black political agenda and who will set the standards by which the leaders are judged. This kind of ideological infighting has gone on at the top tier of black leadership for decades" (Horowitz, 1994), providing another acknowledgement the existence of this ongoing debacle.

This long-standing ideological feud over the best way to combat racism in U.S. culture does not only exist when one Black leader is positioned against another but when the approaches of one leader are critiqued. For example, President Barack Obama was not a social justice leader in a traditional sense, but his moderate approaches to social justice issues affecting the Black community received significant criticism during his presidency. As Ta-Nehisi Coates (2012) wrote for *The Atlantic*, "despite his sloganeering for change and progress, Obama is a conservative revolutionary, and nowhere is his conservative character revealed more than in the very sphere where he holds singular gravity—race." Coates and many others both in academic scholarship and the popular press have written at length about Obama's refusal to use radical tactics to address America's racial issues, such as Keeanga-Yamhata Taylor (2016), Michael Eric Dyson (2016), and Cornel West (2017), to name a few. Many believe Obama was not radical on racial issues as he did not want to alienate white Americans, which illustrates an integrationist attitude.

The news media plays a significant role in stoking this feud as they use frames to position the approaches of activist and political figures in ways that impact their reception. Separatist approaches are often spectacularized, and framed as deviant and anti-white (Grimm, 2015) whereas integrationist approaches that are more amicable to white institutions are framed as successful. Grimm (2015, p. 316) argues that "news media explain normalcy by demonstrating to the audience what is deviant, which results in portraying some groups as frequently in powerful positions while marginalizing or ignoring others." For example, Chloe Banks (2018) observed the impacts news media framing in her research on how Black Lives Matter activists were portrayed in the press as pursuing violent protest tactics. She argues that the binary of "good" and "bad" Black citizenship promoted in the news

media attempted to delegitimize the BLM movement by comparing the actions of movement protestors to that of the Civil Rights Movement in a negative way for not emulating Dr King's peaceful protest. Boykoff and Carrington (2020) argue that in the midst of protests news media attempts to drown out demonstrator's messages by instead focusing on tactics and their appropriateness or lack thereof. They contend that "such discursive strategies are invoked in order to discredit protestors and their concerns" which casts doubt on their right to represent the Black community and disputes validity of the protest (p. 844). The hegemonic framing deployed by the news media can impact a movement's success because a figure's image contributes to who is given power and legitimacy, and how the entire cause is viewed. Dr King understood this during the Civil Rights Movement as he had a reputation for leveraging his relationship with the television news media for his favor (Madrigal, 2018; Torres, 2018). In the present day, neoliberalism has increased how media image has become central to social justice work and therefore shifted activism.

Brand image is further exacerbated by hypermedia culture in the present day. According to Julie Wilson (2017), political issues have become privatized with celebrities and corporations becoming key players at the center of solving social issues. She argues, "in a world where the corporate brand is the primary measure of market value, social and political causes, which used to be outside the scope of business practice, can emerge as 'good business' to the extent that they might enhance a firm's brand value" (p. 185). It is key to note, though, how Jay-Z and Kaepernick's celebrity status and brand played a part in this iteration of this long existing feud.

Black celebrity activism: old feuds in the "new social movement" paradigm

Participation of Black celebrities in social movements is not a new phenomenon. During the Civil Rights Movement stars like Harry Belafonte, Lena Horne, Eartha Kitt, and many others engaged in the movement through their craft, by making statements, and even participating in protests and marches (McNeill, 2015). In the 1980s and 1990s Black entertainers and athletes such as Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, Muhammad Ali, Janet Jackson, and others stood for issues affecting the Black community such as police brutality, the stereotyping of Black people, and lack of resources for Black communities. Contemporarily, we have seen Jesse Williams, Kendrick Lamar, Beyoncé, and more dedicate their celebrity to equality efforts. According to Meyer and Gamson (1995), celebrities can be a resource for social movements in the form of the visibility they bring, drawing in potential supporters, and financial resources. However, for Black celebrities, their contribution to movements is precarious as they wield their position as a celebrity while still being limited to their racial status. As Sarah Jackson (2014) puts it, "Black celebrities—with their bodies, personas, and expressive forms—have unique potential to challenge dominant definitions of race and nation even as they are limited by them" (p. 3).

In previous eras Black celebrities contributed their cultural and financial capital to movements alongside activists and politicians whose work often targeted state and governmental policy and economic redistribution. However, in the present day, social justice has been transformed into a quantifiable

venture filtered through the lens of neoliberal capitalism. Wallace and Andrews (2021) argue that traditional activism has been traded for representation activism which is fueled by the “new social movement paradigm.” This framework suggests, “new social movements are characterized in part by their emphasis on collective identity, symbolic forms of resistance, and counter-hegemonic cultural tactics” and as a result pursue optics at the expense of action (pp. 828–829). To them, representation activism, which is a symptom of celebrity culture, utilizes the *visibility* of Black celebrities doing and discussing issues affecting the Black community as *the activism*. Black celebrities are no longer working with activists such as Dr King, Malcolm X, Al Sharpton, or John Lewis, instead many choose to integrate activism into their brand by taking part in philanthropic efforts. Enrique Laraña et al. (1994) argues that in new social movements, “mobilization factors tend to focus on cultural and symbolic issues that are associated with sentiments of belonging to a differentiated social group where members can feel powerful; they are likely to have subcultural orientations that challenge the dominant system” (p. 10). For example, including a Black man like Jay-Z in the NFL’s CSR work by giving him a “seat at the table” works as a means of symbolic progress and gives him power in a different identity group. This form of action works as a business decision for all brands involved—the NFL who looks good for adding diversity, Jay-Z who is helping his community and being part of a groundbreaking partnership, and Roc-Nation who gets to platform their artists as part of the NFL and social justice.

To Buechler (2011), activism shifting toward profits and brands is a result of neoliberal capitalism. He writes, “if contemporary society is defined by capitalist markets, bureaucratic states, scientized relationships, and instrumental rationality, then new social movements are historically specific responses to these conditions” (p. 159). This is in line with Henry Giroux (2001) who asserts “racial justice in the age of market-based freedoms and financially driven values loses its ethical imperative” because neoliberalism “embraces commercial rather than civic values, private rather than public interests, and financial incentives rather than ethical concerns” (pp. 195–196). Banet-Weiser (2012) corroborates this shift stating that branding politics has become common practice in the corporate world via CSR. She says corporations use social issues “not only to sell products but also to further their brand” (p. 126) She claims, within CSR corporations care less about the actual issue and more so about how supporting the issue can bring profit. The progress the social issue receives is just a “value add” and not necessarily a priority (p. 145). So, in the case of the NFL/Roc Nation partnership, the goal is to bring positive attention to the NFL for their work in race relations by having the most accomplished rapper of all time at the helm. Indeed, the motivations behind NFL and Jay-Z pulling together their resources is a calculated decision that will ultimately benefit both brands while performing social justice for the Black community. As a result, the financial benefit to their private corporations and brands outweighs the backlash and ethical concerns. Moreover, while the main goal may be for corporate revenue and brand advancement, an integrationist approach may say the benefits and positive attention towards the cause still make working alongside white institutions worth it.

To those who utilize an integrationist approach, the access to resources is a benefit. In an interview, Jay-Z stated, “the

NFL has a great big platform, and it has to be all-inclusive (...) They were willing to do some things, to make some changes, that we can do some good” (Aswad, 2019a). To Jay-Z, the partnership with the NFL secured financial capital, access to a wider audience, and legitimization of the social justice efforts from working with such a major recognizable organization. This approach fits with the framework of resource mobilization which according to McCarthy & Zald (1977, p. 1213), “examines the variety of resources that must be mobilized, the linkages of social movements to other groups, [and] the dependence of movements upon external support for success.” Resource mobilization theory adopts an economic approach to understanding collective action, emphasizing how resource flows influence a movement’s emergence and success with an emphasis on working with established organizations and social networks.

As discourses in Black social justice are recycled and repeated, the frame of integrationist versus separatist has reemerged framing Jay-Z’s use of resource mobilization as moderate in comparison to Kaepernick’s then recent protest of the NFL as separatist and therefore radical. Historically, protest and resource mobilization are tactics that have been pitted against one another because early research framed protest as irrational, disorganized, and driven by emotion (van Stekelenburg & Klandermans, 2017) whereas resource mobilization, has been framed as more rational, organization-driven, and effective, especially when in partnership with a white institution.

To demonstrate how the NFL/Roc-Nation partnership exists within the long existing ideological feud of integrationist versus separatism, I will outline the discourse that emerged in the week following the August 13, 2019, announcement.

Method

Drawing from discourse in the popular press and Twitter posts for the week following the announcement of the NFL/Roc-Nation partnership (8/13/2019–8/19/2019), I employed thematic analysis to identify dominant themes and patterns in the discourse responding to the partnership as a social justice tactic. My data set consisted of 93 articles culled via NexusUni utilizing the search terms “Jay-Z” AND/OR “NFL.” These included *The Atlantic*, *The New York Times*, *The Associated Press*, *Fox*, *CNN*, *EURweb*, *The Nation Blogs*, *The Cheat Sheet*, *The Undefeated*, *The Griot*, and *The Root*.

According to John Cable (2017), mainstream news media and social media can work in tandem in activism efforts. The news media works to keep the public informed and people online can work as watchdogs over the news media (p. 194). Due to the 24-hour nature of the online news, people are able to engage with information in real-time as it is published. This makes online discourse from social media a rich site to analyze and get a sense of public opinions, especially in a case such as this one involving community feelings on racial justice approaches. With that in mind, I pulled discourse from Twitter discussing the partnership. I performed an Advanced Search within Twitter’s platform for the terms “Jay-Z” AND/OR “Jay” AND/OR “NFL” for the same time period as the news articles and pulled the first ten tweets related to the partnership on the “Top Tweets” tab for each day of that week. This produced a total number of 105 tweets to analyze.

The purpose of this article is not to provide quantitative data on whether there were more positive or negative responses to the partnership, but rather to examine the discourse from a qualitative perspective. Discussing the value of thematic analysis as a method for researching “othered” communities, scholars [Riger and Sigurvinsdottir \(2016\)](#), contend that thematic analysis is useful for understanding the meanings people give their experiences that give rise to certain behaviors (p. 35). With this in mind, my examination of the discourse from the articles and tweets, considered recurring themes, sentiments, and viewpoints that lend themselves to the contribution of ideologies on how Black American activist work is imagined to best be enacted. The announcement of the partnership gave rise to discourse as a behavioral response which is significant because it illustrates how and what the Black community views as noteworthy. The three dominant themes that emerged within the data were anger over the absence of Kaepernick in the partnership, support for the partnership due to Jay-Z’s business prowess, and distrust of the NFL’s motives. I outline my findings below.

Past kneeling? Anger over Kaepernick’s exclusion

At the August 14, 2019, press conference announcing the partnership, questions about Kaepernick began rolling in almost immediately. In fact, despite “Kaepernick” not being a search term in my sample, almost every single article addressed him when discussing the partnership. When asked about him at the press conference, Jay-Z and Goodell claimed they had spoken with Kaepernick but did not clarify when or about what they spoke. Following the press conference, Kaepernick’s girlfriend Nessa Diab tweeted “THIS is a lie. COLIN never spoke to Jay-Z and NFL ahead of that deal being done. They NEVER included him in any discussion” ([Nitty, 2019](#)). This immediately challenged Jay-Z and the NFL’s credibility. Following her tweet, Kaepernick seemingly confirmed his lack of involvement by tweeting “My Brothers @E_Reid35 @KSTiLLS @iThinkIsee12 continue to fight for the people, even in the face of death threats. They have never moved past the people and continue to put their beliefs into action. Stay strong Brothers!!!” ([Chuck, 2019](#)). It was speculated that this tweet was directed at Jay-Z who at the press conference said, “I think we’ve moved past kneeling. I think it’s time for action” ([Hill, 2019](#)). This statement, coupled with the lack of Kaepernick’s physical presence and exclusion from the partnership discussion, led fans and journalists to be vocal online and in the press about their anger. Moreover, Jay Z’s statement alludes to the belief that protest, like Kaepernick’s, does not equate formal “action” towards the cause.

In my analysis of the news coverage of the partnership I found additional evidence supporting the belief that in working with the NFL, Jay-Z was betraying Kaepernick and lacked commitment to social justice. In an interview on *CNN Tonight*, journalist Jemele Hill stated:

I guess I’m just confused like everybody else why he thinks he even needs the NFL if he wants to continue furthering his social justice causes and why would you partner with the same league who is keeping Colin Kaepernick out of the league and on one end trying to reposition itself as

some kind of social justice champion.” (“Jay-Z’s Roc Nation Entering,” 2019)

Similarly, Dave [Zirin \(2019\)](#), with *The Nation*, wrote, “many saw this as an action that broke a de facto picket line where black entertainers—and white performers acting in solidarity—would not do business with the league as long as exiled quarterback Colin Kaepernick remained unemployed for his anthem protests against police violence.” Hill’s and Zirin’s statements about a proverbial “picket line” demonstrate the way Kaepernick and the NFL were positioned as being on opposing sides.

Conversations online echoed some of the sentiments of the news media about Kaepernick’s absence. For example, one Twitter user tweeted, “I’m really not so romantic about protesting. I haven’t been that girl for some years, now. But Colin Kaepernick risked his livelihood to protest police brutality and you dick-riders are equating Jay Z’s deal with it, while he is risking NOTHING. It’s beyond pathetic.” This tweet displays sentiments of confusion and anger over Kaepernick’s absence and highlights the way protesting and a formal partnership are seen as two separate types of tactics by saying the two aren’t equal. Other online users highlighted the divide within the Black community when it comes to approaches. As one tweet wrote, “If anything this NFL thing is another indicator that all Black people don’t have shared interests and haven’t in 40 years. We all don’t have the same goals despite what some people tell you, and you’re a sucker for thinking we do.” Another said, “Black entrepreneurialism as liberation is once again a huge and efficient divider. It’s why ppl who champion Jay ‘working from within’ mock Reid for doing it because they don’t believe in workers striving to improve working conditions.” The second tweet illustrates the perpetuation of the “working from within” white communities’ issue that divides Black communities. As the first tweet indicates, “all Black people don’t have shared interests.”

The belief that tactics are disparate is reified when corporations punish actions like Kaepernick’s by not re-signing his contract and award Jay-Z with a prestigious partnership. We see this highlighted in the discourse surrounding the second theme that emerged, support for Jay-Z and the partnership.

“Jay has a plan!” support of the partnership

Although a substantial number of responses were critical of the partnership, some of the reactions were positive. Many cultural commentators and fans felt the partnership could actually build off of Kaepernick’s work. Additionally, a major thread within the support of the partnership was rooted in support of Jay-Z and his abilities due to his reputation as a savvy businessperson and previous social justice work. Paul [Newberry \(2019\)](#) wrote for the *Associated Press*, “maybe we’re being too hard on Jay-Z, who has long pulled off that delicate balancing act between social consciousness (such as his Trayvon Martin documentary series) and the potential pitfalls of good ol’ capitalism (…) He’s been on the right side of many issues, but never let it stand in the way of making a buck.” Newberry’s response highlights the contemporary shift towards social justice conflating with generating a profit. Blue [Telusma \(2019\)](#) of *The Grio* shared a similar belief:

While I understand why this stance might anger the anti-capitalist crowd, objectively speaking he does have a point. In a perfect world, the NFL and any other institutions that have played a hand in anti-blackness would disappear into a cloud of smoke and be magically replaced by a more just and equitable bastions of diversity and inclusion. But we don't live in a perfect world, and since the NFL isn't going anywhere anytime soon, there is real merit in having them partner up with accountability partners who will not only call them out when they mess up, but also make sure they come up with solutions that will create change.

This rhetoric from Telusma and Newberry is significant because it illustrates the inherent idea that Jay-Z plus the NFL equals an obvious profit-making venture, but that some good can come from such a partnership. Telusma's statement that the NFL "isn't going anywhere anytime soon" is in the vein of resource mobilization and moderate social justice tactics, a perspective that encourages that working with existing institutions for the greater good is necessary. Moreover, both statements highlight the hegemonic nature of neoliberal capitalism that de-radicalizes activism forcing activists to take on a "if you can't beat them, join them" approach.

Support of Jay-Z's resource mobilization also drew criticism of Kaepernick's tactic as the two continued to be pitted against one another. One Twitter user wrote, "kneeling is not gonna provide the resource and influence victims of social injustice need to fight for themselves. Jay been standing with action 2013." Some Twitter users went as far as comparing the two to Dr King and Malcolm X such as one that stated, "We had a Dr MLK Jr. & Malcolm X for a reason! We have a Jay Z & a Colin Kaepernick for a reason! Everyone did not accept Dr King's approach initially! Give Jay Z a chance. This is just the beginning, Colin will always be relevant, however, Jay has a plan! #JayZ #Kaepernick #NFL" If we do a close reading of the language of this tweet, it is important to note that Jay-Z's method of working with the NFL is associated with Dr King and having a "plan." Oppositionally, Kaepernick's tactics are not positioned as planful, echoing the idea that protest is disorganized or not goal oriented. The way this situation harkens back to the perceived ideological feud between Dr King and Malcolm X is significant because the tension between Kaepernick and Jay-Z builds upon this history. Jay-Z supporters seemingly agree with using the moderate approach of resource mobilization because it guarantees "a seat at the table," just as it did for Dr King in the 1960s.

In response to the backlash, Jay-Z responded in a verse he was featured on in the song "Flux Capacitor" (2020) stating, "Why would I sell out? I'm already rich, don't make no sense/Got more money than Goodell/a whole NFL bench/Did it one-handed like Odell/handcuffed to a jail/I would've stayed on the sidelines if they could've tackled the shit themselves" (Electronica & Jay-Z). In this stanza, he acknowledges the sellout accusations while attempting to position himself as a necessary savior in this situation. It seems Jay-Z is attempting to align his commitment to the Black community and justify his partnership with the NFL, while still focusing on financial benefits. Hip hop studies research on Jay-Z by scholars like Mark Anthony Neal (2013) and Thomas P. Oates (2020) has noted Jay-Z's use of hip hop cosmopolitanism to straddle the line between being rooted in community and invested in upward mobility. As Oates

(2020, p. 186) puts it, "in order for Jay-Z's career transition to convey defiance rather than a selfish opportunism, he would have to maintain a delicate balance. Even as he moved to the boardroom." This cosmopolitanism that leads to the boardroom is inherently integrationist as upward mobility indicates moving upward into white spaces. However, this calls into question his authenticity or commitment to the cause because the NFL is historically known for its anti-Black practices. This distrust of the NFL emerged in the third and final theme.

Distrust of the NFL's motives

Not all of the heat in the discourse was directed toward Kaepernick and Jay-Z. The NFL received quite a bit of criticism questioning the true intentions of its motives. Many felt its partnership with Jay-Z was not committed to "creating positive change" as the press release stated, but rather was simply an attempt to recuperate its tarnished reputation following the Kaepernick incident. For instance, *Fox News* commentator Jesse Watters ("NFL and Jay-Z Team up," 2019) stated:

It seems like big organizations like the NFL, or like Nike is doing with Kaepernick, they are bringing on the social justice liaisons to help them navigate through tender issues, racial issues, things like that, that might give these big organizations problems. And if you bring a guy with street cred or a guy with his ear to the street or that has great credibility in the black community, that could kind of cushion any sort of negative press that that organization could face.

This highlights the belief that major organizations like the NFL are not experts on race relations and need someone with cultural capital within the Black community to validate its efforts.

It is common for corporations to co-opt social movements and reconfigure them for their own profits (de Bakker et al., 2017). While the NFL may feel as though its efforts are making a difference by "putting its money where their mouth is," unfortunately some social commentators and audiences argued for social justice efforts that are not reactionary. For example, retired NFL player Ephraim Salaam said in an interview with CNN, "I don't think the NFL has done enough since the beginning of this three years ago to move past it. Signing Jay-Z and Roc Nation doesn't alleviate all of the things that they haven't addressed as an organization" ("Jay-Z's Roc Nation," 2019). As a result of the NFL's history of indifference toward the issues facing Black communities, some fans, journalists, and players met the partnership with skepticism.

According to McCarthy and Zald (1977), the entities that provide money, facilities, and even labor for some social movements may have no commitment to the values that underlie specific movements. This is the perception that some articulate about the NFL, suggesting it has no real stake in Black social justice besides the optics that imply that it should be invested in equity. The NFL may provide money, press, and resources, however, social justice efforts that work towards Black liberation and racial equity do not necessarily align with the NFL's ultimate goals of maintaining audiences and garnering ad revenue. The discourse following the announcement of the NFL/Roc-Nation partnership illustrates

that some journalists and fans feel the NFL is skirting around the real issues by not identifying the systemic causes embedded within the need for social justice.

Abraham Iqbal Khan (2016) argues that the relationship between anti-racism and neoliberalism is complicated by what Jodi Dean (2009) calls communicative capitalism. That is, when organizations performatively engage in seemingly political speech without true coalition building. Khan quotes Dean who states, “communicative capitalism is defined by ‘the materialization of ideals of inclusion and participation in information, entertainment, and communication technologies in ways that capture resistance and intensify global capitalism’” (Khan, 2016, p. 41). The NFL’s partnership with Roc-Nation utilizes entertainment and communication technology to engage in political discourse surrounding issues affecting the Black community while still participating in capitalism that ultimately harms Black communities. This is where the potential drawbacks of resource mobilization come into play because it is imperative to assess what the outside organizations add to the movement, what they take away, and what is at stake when organizations, like the NFL, become part of the efforts. Indeed, the NFL’s platform secures resources, capital, and a large audience, however, it falls short on legitimacy to some audiences as the discourse highlights.

Conclusion: Whom is such activism expected to serve?

In an interview addressing the controversy, Jay-Z argued that he and Kaepernick are, “two adult men who disagree on the tactic but are marching for the same cause” (Rosman, 2020). Though he’s speaking metaphorically by using the term “marching,” what Jay-Z suggests is that both he and Kaepernick are both working towards the same goal—drawing attention to racism affecting the Black American community—but the tactics they are using differ. In this article I illustrate how the discourse surrounding the partnership framed Kaepernick’s protest as radical, while Jay-Z’s integrationist approach as being more logical and business-oriented because he utilizes resource mobilization and chooses to integrate with the NFL. Ultimately, though, Jay-Z and Kaepernick are not that different—not unlike many of the Black American activists of yesteryear—they are framed and placed in a perpetuating discourse as oppositional. In discussion of framing, Grimm (2015, p. 316) cites Entman (1993) who argues “frames define problems, diagnose causes, make moral judgments, and suggest remedies.” That is to say, frames shape and develop the discourse. Kaepernick’s approach was only considered to be so because of his celebrity status and because it wasn’t approved by the NFL. The oppositional framing created and fueled by news media, like we saw in the reporting of the NFL and Roc-Nation partnership, takes away from highlighting the actual issues and how they should be tangibly addressed in a systematic way. For example, reporting of the partnership focused on Jay-Z and the NFL as opposed to specifying what “commitment to social justice” meant in their context and what steps would be taken to help the Black community. This is problematic because the lack of specificity allows the initiative to avoid benchmarks, goals, and follow up from the media and community at large.

Banet-Weiser (2012) claims that brand culture is a useful filter through which to examine politics as celebrities and corporate entities are now at the center of public discussion on

activism and progress (p. 136). This contemporary iteration of an ongoing ideological feud illustrates how brand and corporate culture now have a hand in Black activist work. Moreover, brands, whether celebrity or corporate, being at the center of reporting on Black issues co-opt the cause and oftentimes the central issue becomes a footnote. This speaks to the hegemonic neoliberalism of the new social movement paradigm in which corporate entities are privatizing political causes and turning them into opportunities for marketing instead of pushing for government intervention.

Turning systemic issues into a marketing strategy enables representative activism and communicative capitalism that focuses on entertainment value, symbolic representation, and the financial benefits for corporations. Instead of focusing on celebrity images or stoking binaries of opposing approaches, I urge news media and cultural commentators to more critically interrogate the results of celebrity and corporate activism. At the time I am writing this article in September of 2024, there has been much publicity around the halftime performances organized by Jay-Z but no reports or information on what actionable social justice items have been produced as a result of the partnership. Similarly, the hype around Kaepernick’s protest has died down and little to no reporting in the news media discusses any of his activist or community work. Reporting that only focuses on controversy, such as discussing approaches, or branded marketing stories for the celebrities and corporations, takes away from opportunities to develop and investigate stories around what equitable changes are needed for the Black American community.

Data availability

The data underlying this article are available in the article and in its online supplementary material. This is minus the Twitter usernames for the tweets used for analysis which have been de-identified in consideration of account owners’ privacy.

Funding

I received no funding for this work. This research was completed during my time as a doctoral candidate at the Department of Radio-Television-Film at the University of Texas at Austin. I thank the department for the support, Jennifer McClearn especially.

Conflicts of interests: I have no conflict of interest in publishing this work.

Note

1. This analysis relies on public tweets. However, in a similar fashion as scholar Raven Maragh-Lloyd (2020), in consideration of user privacy, I have elected to de-identify Twitter usernames of those who are not public figures as they did not agree for their, though public, tweets to be utilized for research purposes. Maragh-Lloyd relies upon Annette Markham (2012), and Helen Fay Nissenbaum (2010) for research on data, technology, social media, and privacy.

References

- Around the NFL (2019, August 1). Jay-Z’s Roc Nation entering partnership with NFL. *NFL.Com*. <https://www.nfl.com/news/jay-z-s-roc-nation-entering-partnership-with-nfl-0ap3000001041162?campaign=sf:fanshare:facebook>

- Aswad, J. (2019a, August 13). Jay-Z joins forces with N.F.L. for music and social justice campaign. *Variety*. <https://variety.com/2019/biz/news/jay-z-joins-forces-with-n-f-l-for-music-and-social-justice-campaign-1203301091/>
- Aswad, J. (2019b, August 21). 'Half sellout, half savior': What Jay-Z's NFL deal and possible team ownership really mean. *Variety*. <https://variety.com/2019/biz/news/jay-z-nfl-deal-team-ownership-really-mean-lawyers-colin-kaepernick-1203309243/>
- Banet-Weiser, S. (2012). *Authentic TM: the politics and ambivalence in a brand culture*. New York University Press/z-wcorg/.
- Banks, C. (2018). Disciplining Black activism: Post-racial rhetoric, public memory, and decorum in news media framing of the Black Lives Matter movement. *Continuum*, 32(6), 709–720. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10304312.2018.1525920>
- Boykoff, J., & Carrington, B. (2020). Sporting dissent: Colin Kaepernick, NFL activism, and media framing contests. *International Review for the Sociology of Sport*, 55(7), 829–849. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1012690219861594>
- Buechler, S. M. (2011). *Understanding Social Movements: Theories from the Classical Era to the Present*. Paradigm.
- Cable, J. (2017). Communication sciences and the study of social movements. In C. Roggeband & B. Klandermans. *Handbook of social movements across disciplines* (pp. 185–201). Springer International Publishing AG. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-57648-0_7
- Carson, C. (2005). The unfinished dialogue of Martin Luther King, Jr. and Malcolm X. *OAH Magazine of History*, 19(1), 22–26.
- Chuck, S. (2019, August 19). Colin Kaepernick appears to take a shot at Jay-Z with tweet. *Los Angeles Times*. <https://www.latimes.com/sports/story/2019-08-19/colin-kaepernick-jay-z-eric-reid-protests>
- Coates, T.-N. (2012, August 23). Fear of a Black president. *The Atlantic*. <https://www.theatlantic.com/magazine/archive/2012/09/fear-of-a-black-president/309064/>
- Dean, J. (2009). *Democracy and other neoliberal fantasies: Communicative capitalism and left politics*. Duke University Press.
- Economic Policy Institute (2022, June 15). *Disparities chartbook: Economic disparities by race and ethnicity*. Economic Policy Institute. <https://www.epi.org/publication/disparities-chartbook/>
- de Bakker, F. G. A., den Hond, F., & Laamanen, M. (2017). Social movements: Organizations and organizing. In C. Roggeband & B. Klandermans (Eds.), *Handbook of social movements across disciplines* (pp. 203–231). Springer International Publishing. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-57648-0_8
- Duvall, S.-S., & Heckemeyer, N. (2018). #BlackLivesMatter: Black celebrity hashtag activism and the discursive formation of a social Movement. *Celebrity Studies*, 9(3), 391–408. <https://doi.org/10.1080/19392397.2018.1440247>
- Dyson, M. E. (2016). *The Black presidency: Barack Obama and the politics of race in America*. Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.
- Electronica, J., & Jay, Z. (2020). *Flux capacitor. A written testimony [Album]*. Reservoir Media Group, Universal Music Publishing.
- Frontline (2023, November 3). *The Debate Between W.E.B. Du Bois and Booker T. Washington*. Frontline PBS. <https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/article/debate-w-e-b-du-bois-and-booker-t-washington/>. Date accessed November 11, 2023.
- Gibson, R. A., Booker, T., & Washington, W. E. B. (2019). *DuBois: The problem of Negro Leadership (Curriculum Unit 78.02.02; Curriculum Units by Fellows of the Yale-New Haven Teachers Institute)*. Yale-New Haven Teachers Institute.
- Giroux, H. A. (2001). Private satisfactions and public disorders: "Fight Club," patriarchy, and the politics of masculine violence. *JAC*, 21(1), 1–31. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/20866386>
- Giroux, H. A. (2002). Neoliberalism, corporate culture, and the promise of higher education: The university as a democratic public sphere. *Harvard Educational Review*, 72(4), 425–464.
- Grimm, J. (2015). Hegemonic framing of Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. in northeastern newspapers. *Howard Journal of Communications*, 26(3), 313–332. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10646175.2015.1049761>
- Hariot, M. (2019, August 15). Not like this: An open letter to Jay-Z. *The Root*. <https://www.theroot.com/not-like-this-an-open-letter-to-jay-z-1837268769>
- Hill, J. (2019, August 15). Jay-Z helped the NFL banish Colin Kaepernick. *The Atlantic*. <https://www.theatlantic.com/ideas/archive/2019/08/jay-z-helps-nfl-banish-colin-kaepernick/596146/>
- Hill, S. (2019, August 14). Jay-Z on NFL Partnership: We've Moved Past Kneeling. Let's Take Action. Black Enterprise. <https://www.blackenterprise.com/jay-z-nfl-partnership-passed-kneeling-action/>
- Horowitz, C. (1994, April 4). The Sharpton generation. *New York Magazine*. <https://nymag.com/news/features/48884/>. Date accessed November 12, 2023.
- Hosenball, M. (2001, April 8). Jesse and Al's food fight. *Newsweek*. <https://www.newsweek.com/jesse-and-als-food-fight-150187>
- Hutchinson, E. O. (1993). The continuing myth of Black capitalism. *The Black Scholar*, 23(1), 16–21.
- Jackson, S. J. (2014). *Black celebrity, racial politics, and the press: framing dissent* by Sarah J. Jackson. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315887043>
- Jay-Z's Roc Nation Entering Partnership With NFL (2019, August 14). CNN tonight. CNN. <http://transcripts.cnn.com/TRANSCRIPTS/190814/cnnt.02.html>
- Khan, A. I. (2016). A rant good for business: Communicative capitalism and the capture of anti-racist resistance. *Popular Communication*, 14(1), 39–48. <https://doi.org/10.1080/15405702.2015.1084629>
- Laraña, E., Johnston, H., & Gusfield, J. R. (1994). *New social movements: From ideology to identity*. Temple University Press.
- Lockhart, P. (2019, September 9). Jay-Z's new NFL partnership and the backlash to it explained. *Vox*. <https://www.vox.com/culture/2019/8/16/20808892/jay-z-nfl-kaepernick-roc-nation-partnership-inspire-change-criticism>
- Madrigal, A. C. (2018). April 2). When the revolution was televised. *The Atlantic*. <https://www.theatlantic.com/technology/archive/2018/04/televisions-civil-rights-revolution/554639/>
- Maney, G. M., Kutz-Flamenbaum, R. V., Rohlinger, D. A., & Goodwin, J. (Eds.) (2012). *Strategies for social change*. University of Minnesota Press.
- Maragh-Lloyd, R. (2020). Black Twitter as semi-enclave. In L. K. Lopez (Ed.), *Race and media* (p. 163–177). NYU Press. <https://doi.org/10.2307/j.ctv11vcbf.17>
- Markham, A. (2012). Fabrication as ethical practice. *Information, Communication & Society*, 15(3), 334–353. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2011.641993>
- McCarthy, J. D., & Zald, M. N. (1977). Resource mobilization and social movements: A partial theory. *American Journal of Sociology*, 82(6), 1212–1241.
- McNeill, B. (2015, April 24). Hollywood celebrities' unsung role in the civil rights movement. *VCU News*. <https://news.vcu.edu/article/hollywood-celebrities-unsung-role-in-the-civil-rights-movement>. Date accessed November 11, 2023.
- Meyer, D. S., & Gamson, J. (1995, April) The challenge of cultural elites: Celebrities and social movements. *Sociological Inquiry*, 65(2), 181–206. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1475-682X.1995.tb00412.x>
- Mumford, N. E. (2019). August 15). Opinion | Jay-Z and the NFL: Thanks, but I'll take a knee *Washington Post* https://www.washingtonpost.com/opinions/jay-z-and-the-nfl-thanks-but-ill-take-a-knee/2019/08/15/d436c3ae-bf91-11e9-a5c6-1e74f7ec4a93_story.html
- Neal, M. A. (2013). *Looking for Leroy: Illegible Black masculinities*. New York University Press. ProQuest eBook Central. <http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/utxa/detail.action?docID=1154168>
- Nitty, N. (2019, August 13). THIS is a lie. COLIN never spoke to Jay-Z and NFL ahead of that deal being done. They NEVER included him in any discussion. [Tweet]. *Twitter*. <https://twitter.com/nessnitty/status/1161716216958001152>
- Newberry, P. (2019, August 15). Column: Jay-Z sells out Kaepernick, grabs big money from NFL. *AP NEWS*. <https://apnews.com/fe539d1c5d9045d98cfdcf7f028baff9>
- Newfield, J. (2002, January 7). Rev Vs. Rev. *New York Magazine*. <https://nymag.com/nymetro/news/politics/national/2004race/5570/>

- Nissenbaum, H. F. (2010). *Privacy in context technology, policy, and the integrity of social life*/Helen Nissenbaum. Stanford Law Books. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9780804772891>
- NFL and Jay-Z team up for social justice partnership. (2019, August 15). The ingraham angle. *Fox News*. <https://www.foxnews.com/transcript/nfl-and-jay-z-team-up-for-social-justice-partnership>
- Oates, T. P. (2020). "Where I'm from": Jay-Z's "Hip Hop Cosmopolitanism," basketball, and the neoliberal politics of urban space. *Sociology of Sport Journal*, 37(3), 183–191. <https://doi.org/10.1123/ssj.2019-0045>
- Reyes, L. (2019, August 14). Jay-Z, Roger Goodell explain partnership between Roc Nation, NFL: "This is action." *USA TODAY*. <https://www.usatoday.com/story/sports/nfl/2019/08/14/jay-z-nfl-roc-nation-partnership-social-activism-goodell/2011022001/>
- Riger, S., & Sigurvinsdottir, R. (2016). Thematic analysis. In L. A. Jason & D. S. Glenwick (Eds.), *Handbook of methodological approaches to community-based research: Qualitative, quantitative, and mixed methods* (pp. 33–41). Oxford University Press.
- Rosman, K. (2020, February 1). Jay-Z takes on the Super Bowl. *The New York Times*. <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/02/01/style/jay-z-super-bowl-roc-nation.html>
- Taylor, K.-Y. (2016). *From #BlackLivesMatter to Black liberation*/Keeanga-Yamabhta Taylor. Haymarket Books.
- Telusma, B. (2019, August 14). The Kaepernick Effect: Is Jay-Z's new deal with the NFL a conflict of interests? *TheGrio*. <https://thegrio.com/2019/08/14/the-kaepernick-effect-is-jay-zs-new-deal-with-the-nfl-a-conflict-of-interests/>
- Thompson, K. (2023, July 12). ESPN report sheds light on how Robert Kraft got Jay-Z to partner with NFL amid Kaepernick fallout. *Boston.com*. <https://www.boston.com/sports/new-england-patriots/2023/07/12/espn-report-robert-kraft-jay-z>. Date accessed March 19, 2024.
- Torres, S. (2018). *Black, White, and in color: Television and Black civil rights*. Princeton University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9780691186375>
- van Stekelenburg, J., & Klandermans, B. (2017). Individuals in movements: A social psychology of Contention. In C. Roggeband & B. Klandermans (Eds.), *Handbook of social movements across disciplines*. (pp. 103–139). Springer International Publishing. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-57648-0_5
- Villemez, W. J., & Beggs, J. J. (1984). Black capitalism and Black inequality: Some sociological considerations. *Social Forces*, 63 (1), 117–144.
- Wallace, B., & Andrews, D. L. (2021, March 16). The limits of representation activism: Analyzing Black celebrity politics in LeBron James' The Shop. *Media, Culture, & Society*, 43(5), 825–841. <https://doi-org.proxy.wm.edu/10.1177/0163443721999952>
- West, C. (2017, January 9). Pity the sad legacy of Barack Obama. *The Guardian*. <https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2017/jan/09/barack-obama-legacy-presidency>
- Wilson, J. (2017). *Neoliberalism*. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315623085>
- Zirin, D. (2019, August 19). Jay-Z isn't a sellout, he's a capitalist. *The Nation*. <https://www.thenation.com/article/archive/jay-z-kaepernick-nfl/>